

Searching Online

Chances are good that someone else has had the same problem you're having and has written about it online. Good searching skills and specific inquiries will help you find existing resources to solve the issue you're facing. For example, if you're struggling to install the latest version of Python on a new Windows system, searching for *install python windows* and limiting the results to resources from the last year might direct you to a clear answer.

Searching the exact error message can be extremely helpful too. For example, say you get the following error when you try to run a Python program from a terminal on a new Windows system:

```
> python hello_world.py
Python was not found; run without arguments to install from the Microsoft
Store...
```

Searching for the full phrase, “Python was not found; run without arguments to install from the Microsoft Store,” will probably yield some good advice.

When you start searching for programming-related topics, a few sites will appear repeatedly. I'll describe some of these sites briefly, so you'll know how helpful they're likely to be.

Stack Overflow

Stack Overflow (<https://stackoverflow.com>) is one of the most popular question-and-answer sites for programmers, and it will often appear in the first page of results on Python-related searches. Members post questions when they're stuck, and other members try to give helpful responses. Users can vote for the responses they find most helpful, so the best answers are usually the first ones you'll find.

Many basic Python questions have very clear answers on Stack Overflow, because the community has refined them over time. Users are encouraged to post updates, too, so responses tend to stay relatively current. At the time of this writing, almost two million Python-related questions have been answered on Stack Overflow.

There's one expectation you should be aware of before posting on Stack Overflow. Questions are meant to be the shortest example of the kind of issue you're facing. If you post 5–20 lines of code that generate the error you're facing, and if you address the questions mentioned in “First Steps” on page 477 earlier in this appendix, someone will probably help you. If you share a link to a project with multiple large files, people will be very unlikely to help. There's a great guide to writing up a good question at <https://stackoverflow.com/help/how-to-ask>. The suggestions in this guide are applicable to getting help in any community of programmers.

The Official Python Documentation

The official Python documentation (<https://docs.python.org>) is a bit more hit-or-miss for beginners, because its purpose is more to document the